HACK876 × UNIVERSAL SERVICE FUND

PRIVATE PARTNERSHIP PROPOSAL

Connectivity, put to work by young Jamaicans.

The USF connects Jamaicans and invests in the skills to use that access. Hack876 is one day where secondary-school students do exactly that, building real things on a reliable connection.

Kingston, Jamaica · Feb 20, 2027 (tentative)



80
STUDENTS

9
SCHOOL NETWORK

1
DAY

One day to build something that should exist.

Meet Hack876.



Hack876 is a one-day build competition for approximately **80 secondary-school students** from 5th Form through Upper 6th Form, working in teams of 3 to 4, roughly 20 teams in all, on Saturday, February 20, 2027 (tentative).

Teams pick a real problem, use modern tools including AI, get guidance from mentors, and finish the day with a working prototype and a pitch to judges. It is not a school assignment and there is no answer key.

Our **9-school network** in Kingston is made up of the schools where the Hack876 team currently has relationships and can coordinate most reliably. It is not an exclusive eligibility list.

BUILD SOMETHING THAT SHOULD EXIST.

Connectivity matched with capacity.

Hack876 is where secondary-school students turn access into something they built themselves.

CHARLTON MCFARLANE, CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER, UNIVERSAL SERVICE FUND (2026)

“These grants are important because connectivity must be matched with capacity. By investing in education and digital skills we are helping to ensure that more Jamaicans can participate in, contribute to, and shape Jamaica's digital transformation.”[2]

The USF, an agency under the Ministry of Energy, Transport and Telecommunications, is mandated to bridge the digital divide by ensuring Jamaicans have access to ICT.[2]

For 25 years the USF has run the ICT Education Grant Programme, including an Emerging Digital Leaders Grant for people aged 17 to 28.[2]

The USF supports ICT clubs in more than 35 secondary schools, alongside free public Wi-Fi and Community Access Points.[3]

In 2024 the USF ran Crack the Code, a youth coding competition for Jamaicans 21 and under, with a laptop for first place.[4]

The USF has served as Official Connectivity Partner for a JISA schools event, describing its belief in "powering opportunities through connectivity".[5]

From access to ability.

SKILLS

ICT clubs in schools

USF ICT clubs launched in 16 high schools in 2023, focused on coding, robotics and machine learning, with Ministry of Education endorsement.[6]

COMPETITION

Crack the Code

A November 2024 challenge where young Jamaicans fixed HTML and CSS until they had working web pages.[4]

DEVICES

Connect-a-Child

630 students across Jamaica received free tablets at the 2026 Connect-a-Child Awards Ceremony.[3]

TALENT

ICT Education Grants

Twelve Jamaicans received grants in 2026, chosen from more than 130 applicants.[2]

ACCESS

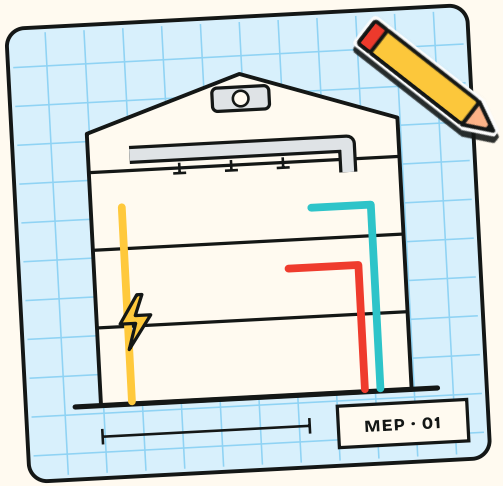
Public Wi-Fi

Plans for 126 new Wi-Fi sites in 2026/27 to complement Community Access Points.[7]

EVENTS

Official Connectivity Partner

The USF has sponsored connectivity for a youth schools event, the JISA meet.[5]



The USF already builds the access and the skills. Hack876 is a place to see both at work in one room.

9 schools. One room.

Hack876 begins with the schools where we already have relationships and can coordinate most reliably for the inaugural staging. Formal confirmations are still in progress, and the network is not an exclusive eligibility list.

- Hillel Academy
- Campion College
- Jamaica College
- Immaculate Conception High School
- Wolmer's
- Ardenne High School
- American International School of Kingston
- St. Andrew High School for Girls
- St. George's College

There are two natural homes for this inside the USF.

CONNECTIVITY

A Connectivity Partner for the day

- Reliable internet for every team on a school campus
- Shaped around whatever the USF is able to provide
- A formal letter to the CEO, with Marketing and Public Relations copied
- We will follow the USF's own approval process and timelines

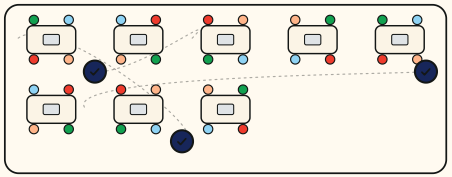
PEOPLE

USF people in the room

- Technical staff as mentors on networks and connectivity
- A short talk on connectivity and capacity
- Information for older students on the ICT Education Grant

The USF's contribution does not have to be purely financial.

PEOPLE IN THE ROOM.



01
Connectivity

USF advice or support so every team stays online from start to finish.

02
Mentors

Network and technical staff who help teams get unstuck, without building the project for them.

03
Speaker

A short, practical talk on what young people can do with access, not only how to get it.

04
Award presenters

The USF team presents any USF award on stage at the close.

05
Grant information

A simple handout on the ICT Education Grant for students old enough to apply, shared through their schools.

GROUND RULES WE WILL HOLD OURSELVES TO

No marketing to students and no sign-ups on the day. Grant information goes out through schools only.

No collection of student contact details or data by sponsors. Photos and names only with school and parent consent.

Any devices or connectivity are used under adult supervision, and the judging panel decides every award.

Become a Connectivity Partner of the inaugural Hack876.

In kind

CONNECTIVITY PARTNER · INAUGURAL HACK876

An in-kind connectivity role mirrors what the USF already does for youth events, and it keeps the request simple for a public agency.

- Event connectivity, such as Wi-Fi capacity for the venue on the day
- Devices as prizes, such as laptops or tablets, if the USF can provide them
- A USF speaker on connectivity, digital skills and the ICT Education Grant
- Mentors from the USF projects and technical teams

PROPOSED RECOGNITION

Universal Service Fund

Connectivity Partner · Inaugural Hack876

Closest Hack876 tracks: Learn, Life

08 WHERE A CONTRIBUTION GOES

No contribution has to cover a whole cost.

WHAT A CONTRIBUTION COULD SUPPORT

- **Equipment.** Helps support the equipment teams build with.
- **Programming.** Helps support mentoring, judging and the student programme.

A sponsor can support the event overall, or agree a specific use with the Hack876 team. No contribution has to cover a whole cost.

In-kind & Community Support

For devices, gift cards, meals, refreshments, supplies, connectivity, expertise, and for contributions below J$50,000.

A meaningful in-kind contribution can be recognized at an equivalent level, based on a usable value agreed together. The advertised value of software credits or volunteer hours is not counted as cash automatically.

AN IDEA, NOT YET A HACK876 AWARD

USF Digital Inclusion Award (proposed)

A suggestion only: an award for the build that best widens access to technology or digital skills. Criteria would be agreed together, and the judging panel would decide.

09 A DIRECT LINE

There is no faceless sponsorship process here.

This proposal is for **Charlton McFarlane, Chief Executive Officer, Universal Service Fund.**[1]

If the USF is interested, we can decide together what involvement should actually look like.

QUESTIONS WE WOULD ANSWER TOGETHER

- ✓ How does this fit the USF's mandate on digital inclusion?
- ✓ Is Hack876 a registered entity, and who would we contract with?
- ✓ Which schools take part, and how could students from underserved communities be included in future?
- ✓ What lead time does the USF need for approval?
- ✓ What exactly would connectivity support involve on the day?
- ✓ How are students protected on consent, data and marketing?

A conversation, not a workload.

Deliberately focused.

Our vision is national. This inaugural staging does not have national-event resources, and we will not pretend it does.

Approximately 80 students. A school network of 9 in Kingston. One day, done properly.

Build the first one well.
Learn from it.
Earn the right to make the second one bigger.

2027

Help make the first Hack876 happen.

No multi-year commitment required.

FUTURE POSSIBILITIES, ONLY IF BOTH SIDES FIND IT VALUABLE. NOT COMMITMENTS.

- A Hack876 edition hosted with USF ICT club schools in other parishes.
- A Crack the Code style online challenge that leads into Hack876.
- A recurring USF Digital Inclusion Award at every Hack876.
- A past ICT Education Grant recipient speaking to students, if the USF would like to make the introduction.



HACK876 × UNIVERSAL SERVICE FUND

Somewhere in that room may be a future founder, engineer, designer or leader.

They do not need us to decide who they become.

They need an opportunity to begin.

HELP US BUILD THAT OPPORTUNITY.

We would welcome a conversation with Mr. McFarlane and the USF team about the right first step.

Kingston, Jamaica · Feb 20, 2027 (tentative)

hack876.com info@hack876.com

SOURCES

1. Universal Service Fund, "Management Team." usf.gov.jm/management-team/
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3. Jamaica Information Service, "Young People Encouraged to Leverage Technology to Develop Innovative Solutions (September 16, 2026)." jis.gov.jm/young-people-encouraged-to-leverage-technology-to-develop-innovative-solutions/
4. Jamaica Observer, "Winners announced for USF's Crack the Code competition (December 18, 2024)." www.jamaicaobserver.com/2024/12/18/winners-announced-usfs-crack-code-competition/
5. Universal Service Fund (LinkedIn), "Official Connectivity Partner for the JISA event." www.linkedin.com/posts/usfjamaica_usf-connect2progress-jisa-activity-7453084003647217665-FWdh
6. Jamaica Information Service, "Sixteen Schools Launch USF ICT Clubs (November 11, 2023)." jis.gov.jm/sixteen-schools-launch-usf-ict-clubs/
7. Jamaica Observer, "USF to expand Jamaica's digital infrastructure in 2026/27 (March 3, 2026)." www.jamaicaobserver.com/2026/03/03/usf-expand-jamaicas-digital-infrastructure-2026-27/

A private partnership proposal prepared for Charlton McFarlane, Chief Executive Officer, Universal Service Fund.